

GatorBait

M A G A Z I N E

OLE MISS WEEK · SEPTEMBER 2026 · REVIEW EDITION



Jadan Baugh celebrates at Auburn. Photograph by Chris Spears / GatorBait Media.

BUDDY MARTIN

SATURDAY'S BILL COMES DUE

Buddy Martin on The Promise, the memory and the next test. Four complete articles from the GatorBait newsroom.

FOUR COMPLETE ARTICLES

OLE MISS WEEK

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Saturday's Bill Comes Due: Gators, Ole Miss, and 'The Promise' That Started It All

BY BUDDY MARTIN

I have this running debate with my podcast colleague Shane Matthews, who oddly enough is a traditionalist, but says one game doesn't have a bearing on the history of what will happen next.

I get what Shane is referencing, but if that were true, we would never be able to connect the dots, which is what tracing history is all about.

So what did that time-honored phrase by philosopher George Santayana mean, when he wrote in his 1905 book "The Life of Reason: Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it?"

And think about that statue of Tim Tebow, when you harken back to 18 years ago.

The Florida Gators should say "thank you" to Ole Miss Saturday for beating them 18 years ago and providing the motivation for another national championship. Now they can show their gratitude by kicking the Rebels' ass and getting Jon Sumrall's team over the hump in 2026.

Saturday afternoon at 3:30, the No. 4 team in the country walks into The Swamp as Sumrall's 3-0 Gators get their first real measuring stick of this season. Ole Miss comes in loaded, fresh off throttling a top-10 LSU team in Oxford, the same swagger Florida carried in 2008 right up until the moment these two teams met and the Rebels took it away from them.

Ole Miss has also won the last meeting, a 34-24 beatdown in Oxford last November. There's a debt on the table here, and it's older than most of the players on either sideline.

Eighteen years ago, on a Saturday afternoon — not a night game, a 12:30 kickoff under a September sun — Florida and Ole Miss played a game that still shapes how this program thinks about itself.

Fourth-ranked, unbeaten Florida had just lost to Ole Miss, 31-30, at home, with a Kentrell Lockett blocked extra point three minutes earlier turning out to be the difference.

Fourth-and-1. Ole Miss 32-yard line. Forty-one seconds left. Florida trailing 31-30. Everybody in the building — everybody in the country, for that matter — knew what was coming. Tim Tebow was getting the ball, because Tebow always got the ball in that spot, and Tebow always got the yard. Not this time. Ole Miss stacked ten men close to the line, Peria Jerry and the Rebels front collapsed the pocket before Tebow ever got started, and the most unstoppable short-yardage weapon in college football was stopped cold, short of the sticks, short of history.

Jerry was Ole Miss's senior defensive tackle on the 2008 roster and a team captain that year. On the decisive fourth-and-1 at the Ole Miss 32 with 41 seconds left, Jerry was central to the stop — he "submarined" right tackle Jason Watkins and also took out right guard Mike Pouncey, collapsing the lead blocker's path before Tebow was dragged down. ESPN's SEC recap stated, "Peria Jerry and a host of his Ole Miss defensive mates smothered Florida quarterback Tim Tebow on fourth-and-short to seal the 31-30 upset."

Kentrell Lockett had blocked the extra point.

With 3:28 left, after Percy Harvin's 15-yard touchdown run cut it to 31-30, Lockett broke through and blocked Jonathan Phillips' potential game-tying extra point — his

first career kick block. Urban Meyer argued Lockett had illegally jumped over the line, but officials upheld the block.

My colleague back then, Brady Ackerman, in a post game streaming show, said, “Well there goes the national championship!” And I swear I said to him, “Not necessarily!” That’s how I remember it.

What Urban Remembers

Urban Meyer walked into his own locker room that afternoon and didn’t recognize what he found. His quarterback was sitting on the floor, alone, tears running down his face. “He was pretty emotional,” Meyer would recall years later. “He was just sitting there.” Meyer just sat down on the floor next to him.

“I didn’t want him to do what he did,” Meyer admitted about what came next. “I hate it when a player puts himself out there like that. People rip him if things don’t work out.” And that’s the thing about Meyer’s version of this story — he genuinely hated it in the moment, said so plainly, and yet cared enough about what his quarterback had said that he had those exact words engraved on a plaque outside the football complex before the next season even started. He hated it and made it permanent. Both things were true.

What Tebow Remembers

Tebow’s own memory is just as bare. “I sat there on the floor, leaning against Coach Meyer,” he said. “We were trying to figure out what we did wrong, what we could do better, how did this happen? I was crying. And then, my parents came in and I got emotional again.”

What didn’t come out publicly until years afterward was that receiver Louis Murphy had to talk a sobbing Tebow off the floor and get him composed enough to walk to that podium at all.

I was sitting about 10 feet from Tebow a few minutes later at that press conference. I’ve written a lot of sentences in my life, but I’ve never found one strong enough to describe watching a 21-year-old with his eyes still wet, his voice cracking, saying what came next.

“I just want to say one thing to the fans and everybody in Gator Nation. I’m sorry. Extremely sorry. We were hoping for an undefeated season. That was my goal. It’s something Florida’s never done here. But I promise you one thing: a lot of good will come out of this. You have never seen any player in the entire country play as hard as I will play the rest of this season, and you’ll never see someone push the rest of the team as hard as I will push everybody the rest of this season. You’ll never see a team play harder than we will the rest of the season. God bless.”

I turned to my cohort Franz Beard afterwards and said, “Did he say what I think he just said?”

Standing ten feet away, I honestly didn’t know if I was watching conviction or desperation. Neither did Meyer, by his own admission. “I was really disappointed” that he gave that speech, Meyer said years later, worried a losing season would turn a raw, honest moment into a punchline.

It wasn’t a punchline. Florida didn’t lose again. Ten straight wins, an SEC Championship beatdown of No. 1 Alabama, and a 24-14 dismantling of Oklahoma for the BCS national title — the second Meyer and Tebow won together in three years.

Back to Saturday

Which brings us back to 3:30 this Saturday, another day game, another shot at Ole Miss in The Swamp. Sumrall’s Gators are 3-0 for the first time since 2019, coming off a win at Auburn where Florida watched a 17-point fourth-quarter lead shrink to five before closing it out, 44-39.

The Gators have opened as home favorites with a spread ranging from -2.5 to -3 points.

Sumrall doesn’t talk in promises. He talks in standards — no bad wins, no days off, prove people right or wrong. But standards mean nothing until they’re tested against a team that’s better than you on paper, and a No. 4 Ole Miss team that just took down a top-10 LSU squad is exactly that test.

Will that have any influence on the outcome of what happened in 2008?

Nobody needs a sequel to what happened in that locker room. That story already got its ending — a crystal football in January. But there's something fitting about Ole Miss being the team standing across the line as Sumrall tries to prove his Gators belong with the big boys again.

The Rebels didn't just beat Florida that Saturday afternoon in 2008. They handed a devastated 21-year-old the reason he needed to become the most relentless competitor this program has ever had.

Whatever happens this Saturday, that debt is worth remembering — not with bitterness, but with the kind of respect you owe an opponent who, without meaning to, helped build a champion.

I was there for the tears in 2008. And I'll be there Saturday for whatever comes next.

Is there real connection between 2008 and 2026? Perhaps not, but for those of us who were in both places, that emotional link will always be there, which is part of the history Tim Tebow bequeathed us. And for which Gator fans should always be eternally grateful. Turns out it was one of the greatest losses in Florida football history. Put that in your Hotty Damn Toddy!

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Sumrall Cussing: His Wife Wants Him To Please Stop. Damn!

BY BUDDY MARTIN

"Yeah, I cuss after the game sometimes... my wife's tried for years to get me to stop," Sumrall said.

Is Jon Sumrall building a reputation as college football's newest potty mouth?

The question came up because of that postgame locker room video — the one where the F-word turned into a full-throated chant after Florida's win at Auburn.

Naturally, some corners of the internet decided the clip had to be AI-generated, because nothing says 2026 like blaming a robot for your program's language problem.

Sumrall, to his credit, didn't fight very hard to clear his own name. He allowed that it might've been AI. Sure. And I've got some primo Ocala swampland to sell you, too. Not so fast, my friend!

Here's the truth few want to print: Virtually every coach I've ever covered cusses, some of them in language so blue that it would make a longshoreman blush red.

The rare exception was Steve Spurrier, who never let the F-word slip in public even when it was practically the house dialect of the sport around him.

Sumrall isn't hiding behind Spurrier's discipline, and he isn't pretending otherwise.

"Yeah, I cuss after the game sometimes... my wife's tried for years to get me to stop," Sumrall said, which is either an admission or a marriage counseling referral, depending on how you read it.

Asked, half-jokingly, whether it was actually him doing the cussing in that locker room video, Sumrall leaned all the way in:

"My wife's tried for years to get me to stop — that's not going real well for either one of us. At SEC Media Days on the main stage I cussed once, I think — Pete Golding cussed a lot more than I did.

"Then I went on the SEC Network stage and Coach Saban was telling me a story off-set and he cussed. I asked him, 'Coach, will you tell that same story on air, exactly like that?' And he did — that's when he told me we needed to get Florida going, since he's a Florida resident now, and he used a cuss word or two in there.

"The main reason I wanted Coach Saban to do it is because I could tell my mom that if Coach Saban did it, it was okay for me to do it too."

It sounds like the F-Athon was leaked by a third party.

Sumrall said players aren't allowed to shoot video in the locker room and suggested somebody must have snuck a camera in. "I think it was AI," he said.

Give the man credit for commitment to the bit. He's got Nick Saban as his character witness and his mother as the jury. That's a defense strategy I can respect.

One Thing He Wasn't Cussing About

Sumrall found plenty to be genuinely happy about after beating Auburn — starting with a tight end room that's gone from afterthought to weapon in about seven months flat.

Credit for the turnaround goes to tight ends coach Evan McKissack, and Sumrall wasn't shy about handing it over. He labeled the group the program's "Most Improved

Room,” which, coming from a coach who just admitted to a chronic cussing problem, is about as close to a papal blessing as you’re going to get.

Sumrall didn’t sugarcoat where the group started, either:

“I’ll be very honest with you. I told our offensive staff in the middle of spring, I’m like, I feel like that room right now is the land of misfit toys — like who’s what? Coach McKissack has done an unbelievable job. That group has grown as much as any group I’ve seen in a stretch from I would say February to right now as any position group I’ve ever been affiliated with in this game — it’s really cool to see. I’m very proud of all of them,” Sumrall said, adding, “I trust those guys as much as I trust anybody.”

From “land of misfit toys” to “I trust those guys as much as I trust anybody” in one offseason. That’s not a metaphor coaches usually get to flip that fast.

Who’s in the Room

Luke Harpring (Jr.) — caught an 11-yard pass against Auburn; Sumrall called him a “Swiss Army knife” who’s good at a little bit of everything.

Amir Jackson (Jr.) — hauled in a 48-yard reception off a double pass from wideout Kahleil Jackson on third-and-8. He ranked No. 2 nationally among tight ends in PFF’s run-blocking grades, as reported September 21.

Lacota Dippre (Sr.) — sprung Jadan Baugh’s 53-yard touchdown run on fourth-and-1 by taking on two defenders as a lead fullback-blocker; he’d been Florida’s offensive player of the week the prior week despite zero stat-sheet production.

Evan Chieca (Sr.) — made his Florida debut against Auburn and sealed Baugh’s long touchdown run by identifying and blocking linebacker Elijah Melendez.

How They Fit Into the Auburn Win

Florida beat Auburn 44-39 on the road at Jordan-Hare, giving Sumrall his first SEC win as Gators head coach. Jadan Baugh ran for 162 yards and three touchdowns, and

Aaron Philo threw for 204 yards and a score, according to Florida’s official box score.

But the box score undersells what the tight ends actually did. Amir Jackson’s trick-play 48-yarder kept a scoring drive breathing when it easily could’ve stalled, and Dippre and Chieca combined to physically clear the lane for Baugh’s 53-yard touchdown burst — the exact kind of unglamorous, high-IQ work that doesn’t show up on a stat sheet but absolutely shows up on a scoreboard.

No wonder Sumrall singled them out afterward. It’s a lot easier to forgive a man his language when his misfit toys are the reason he’s still smiling on the flight home.

A Word on Flags, Not F-Bombs

For all the chatter about what came out of Florida’s mouths in that locker room, the Gators have a more consequential habit to clean up: flags. Florida drew 16 penalties for 138 yards at Auburn. Through games played September 19, cfbstats lists the Gators with 27 penalties in three games — 9.0 per game.

By penalties per game — the fairer, apples-to-apples measure — Syracuse led the nation at 12.0 through September 19, followed by UTSA at 11.3 and UCLA at 10.7. Kansas State was at the other end, averaging 2.7. That’s the language problem that costs actual yardage.

Penalties and all, these Gators were listed as 3.5-point favorites against No. 4 Ole Miss in Monday’s Associated Press report. That line is a dated snapshot, not a promise about where the betting market will settle.

The verdict: Sumrall’s mouth might need a filter, but his tight end room doesn’t need an apology from anybody. One’s a bad habit his wife will keep losing to. The other is a position group that just helped beat Auburn in Jordan-Hare.

I know which one Gator Nation is actually going to remember in December.

Buster Faulkner's offense is anything but predictable

BY FRANZ BEARD



Aaron Philo runs for a first down against Auburn. Photograph by Chris Spears / GatorBait Media.

It was an odd time to call a trick play Saturday night. Second quarter, third-and-8 at the Florida 39, the Gators needing to keep the chains moving to not only to keep Auburn's offense on the sidelines but to quiet the Jordan-Hare crowd that had significantly raised the decibel level following the Tigers' touchdown that trimmed the UF lead to 14-10.

Conventional wisdom says wide receivers run intermediate routes that open things up underneath for a slot or tight end, something effective but safe. Instead, Florida offensive coordinator Buster Faulkner went completely against the grain with a double pass – Aaron Philo with a horizontal pass behind the line of scrimmage to Kahliel Jackson, Kahliel loading up and throwing deep to tight end Amir Jackson, wide open and running behind everybody. Amir had to lay out to bring the ball in at the Auburn 13. Had Kahliel put a little more air under the throw, Amir would have run under it, made the catch and walked into the end zone.

This pass would have gone down as one of those “wasted plays” as Faulkner describes what happens when you resort to trickery, but the Gators wound up with points – a 25-yard field goal from Patrick Durkin – that extended the Florida lead to 17-10. Over on the Auburn sideline, there was rejoicing because the defense had regained its composure to keep the Gators out of the end zone after giving up a 48-yard pass on a trick play.

The Auburn crowd, stunned by the trick play, let out a collective sigh of relief that the Gators had been forced to settle for a field goal rather than grind it in for a touchdown. From a purely psychological standpoint, this was a victory because while the difference between a 17-10 deficit and a 21-10 deficit may only be four points it kept Auburn within a single possession of tying the game.

The play helped put points on the scoreboard, but it also sent a message to every defensive coordinator the Gators will face this season that Buster Faulkner not only has plenty of bullets in his clip, but he's willing to fire away when you least expect it. So, call the double pass exactly what it was – a purpose play. From here on out, every

time Kahliel Jackson is in the game opposing safeties have to be on their heels, knowing Jackson can throw to a receiver who is trying to sneak behind the secondary.

“I’m not known for calling many trick plays, but that one was sound,” Faulkner said Tuesday when speaking to the media. It’s hard for me to call them because sometimes I feel like they’re wasted plays but I also know what they can bring and if they’re at the right time – and that one happened to be at the right time, got the right look, got everything that they wanted and my kids executed at a high level.”

There is no shortage of talented skill people at Faulkner’s disposal but he chose a Jackson-to-Jackson pass play rather than something to Vernell Brown III or Dallas Wilson. Although he played quarterback at Hawthorne High School, Kahliel Jackson had never attempted a pass in a collegiate game. Amir Jackson had four career catches before the diving grab at the Auburn 13. The longest catch of his career went 14 yards against Florida Atlantic in game one.

Once again, method to Faulkner’s madness. Ignore the obvious and go with the least expected, a play call nobody in his right mind would expect executed to near perfection by two guys who had never been part of something so devious.

Through three games, the Gators are No. 2 in the nation in scoring (54 points per game) and third in total offense (544.3 yards per game). They are doing it with an almost 60-40 run-to-pass ratio. The Gators have run the ball 124 times for 738 yards (5.95 per carry) and 12 touchdowns. The Gators have thrown 80 passes, good for 895 yards (11.0 per attempt) and seven touchdowns. Three players have thrown passes, 14 have caught at least one and there have been 11 different ball carriers.

On first down, the Gators have run the ball 69 times for 245 yards (3.55 per carry) and three touchdowns. Thirty-two second down runs have produced 243 yards (7.59 per carry) for six TDs. Third down 17-168 (9.88) and a TD. Fourth down 6-82 (13.67) and one TD. The Gators have

run the ball 66 times in the first half for 289 yards (4.38 per carry) and seven touchdowns. In the second half, they are 58-449 (7.74 per carry) and five touchdowns.

The Gators are 26-30 passing the ball on first down, good for 376 yards and four touchdowns. Second down the Gators are 23-33 for 321 yards and one TD. On third down 10-17 for 189 yards and two touchdowns. All three interceptions the Gators have thrown have come on third down. The Gators are 1-1 on fourth down for nine yards. The Gators are 32-46 for 560 yards and four touchdowns in the first half, 28-35 for 335 yards and three touchdowns in the second half.

A year ago, the Gators averaged 21.6 points and 343.1 yards per game, both down at the bottom of the SEC and outside the top 100 in the country. Early in the third quarter against Auburn, the Gators had already surpassed those numbers on their way to 495 yards and 44 points.

The season is 25 percent complete with eight SEC opponents and Florida State still to be played. Two of the three games so far have been against weaker, non-conference opponents so there is competitive inflation that has to be taken into account, but the consistency and lack of predictability in the play calls are far more revealing than the sheer volume of yardage. Faulkner trusts his troops, which is evident in the way he involves so many players and the willingness to do things like run a trick play with a pair of novices in an SEC road game.

It helps to have a lot of talent on hand. Aaron Philo seems to be the perfect triggerman for the Faulkner offense. Jadan Baugh is the best running back in the country. The dynamic receiving duo of Vernell Brown III and Dallas Wilson will be bolstered by the return of Eric Singleton Jr. from injury, perhaps as early as Saturday when the Gators entertain Ole Miss (3:30 p.m., ABC) in The Swamp. The stars are going to get the football but it is difficult to focus on taking them out when the offensive coordinator spreads the ball around.

“We’ve got a lot of good players,” Faulkner said. “We’ve got to distribute the football and he’s [Philo] done a great job of doing that. I still believe you’ve got to be able to run the football to win in really all the levels of the game

and especially when you go on the road so that's part of who we are and hopefully our identity is starting to be established."

This is easily the best offense the Gators have had since the COVID year of 2020 when Dan Mullen was calling the plays for a team that averaged 39.8 points and 509.8 yards game. That was against a 10-game SEC schedule in a regular season played under very difficult circumstances, which makes those stats even more impressive. Can Faulkner and the 2026 Gators equal or surpass the 2020 team? That remains to be seen since there isn't a single cupcake game on the schedule to artificially inflate the stats. Still on the schedule are games against the likes of Georgia, Oklahoma and Texas who boast fast, athletic defenses so the offensive numbers might not be as gaudy as they are now, but Faulkner's history and tendencies say the Gators will be just fine.

GATORBAIT

Florida After Auburn: 5 Signs Sumrall's Gators Are Rising

BY EDDIE GILLEY



Florida's sideline celebrates at Auburn. Photograph by Chris Spears / GatorBait Media.

Quick Slants

1. Yep, Sumrall is the right guy.

If you still have doubts, this should end all that. Not only did Jon Sumrall lead Florida to a victory in his first SEC road start at Auburn, a place where wins have historically been hard for the Gators to find, but his staff also had Florida looking like the better-coached team. What said the most came afterward. Sumrall took responsibility for the 16 penalties, refused to let his players off the hook and made it clear the standard is higher. He gets SEC football. I have no doubts they will get that cleaned up.

2. Penalties don't always kill you.

Sumrall warned that Florida cannot keep surviving games with that many flags. But there was also an edge to this team that had been missing for a few years. Some penalties were silly. Others came from the kind of physical, emotional football that winning teams often play. Keep the edge. Clean up the mistakes.

The penalties were out of control. I mean, 16 penalties. We won't win another game all year if we do that again.

3. Jadan Baugh is a beast.

Four straight games over 100 yards. Against Auburn, Baugh carried 26 times for 162 net yards and three rushing touchdowns. One bad play did not change his night, and neither did a hand injury. His 53-yard touchdown run in the fourth quarter gave Florida a 41-24 lead and broke the spirits of the Auburn crowd. We agree with Coach Sumrall: we are very thankful No. 13 is still a Gator.

4. The O-Line is going to be OK.

The Gators finished with 243 net rushing yards on 53 attempts, an average of 4.6 per carry. Florida's runners gained 264 yards before losses were deducted. The line also gave Aaron Philo enough time to produce a solid night in the passing game. This unit has become a much more dependable group after plenty of questions at the

start of the season. They can play better, but I love the chip on their shoulders and the little bit of nastiness they bring.

5. The defense played better than it looked on TV.

With 8:45 left in the game, Florida's defense had held Auburn to 208 yards and 24 points, including a field goal after the interception — a huge stop. The final two Auburn drives went 90 and 75 yards, which will drive Brad White and Sumrall crazy. Fourteen points in the final eight minutes is never good, and Florida got hurt playing softer coverage late. But the Gators also finished with seven sacks against a mobile quarterback and held Auburn to 102 net rushing yards. It was not a dominant defensive performance, but it was good enough to win at Jordan-Hare.

War Dang Gator!

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